



OFFICIAL

# NMHS MHS POLICY

## Medication: Exemption from Patient Prescription Co-Payment

|                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Scope (Audience)</b> | All NMHS Mental Health Services (MHS) Community Prescribers                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>Scope (Area)</b>     | All NMHS MHS Community Clinics                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Summary</b>          | Outlines the criteria to be met for NMHS Mental Health Services (MHS) Community Mental Health patients to be granted approval for an exemption from payment for medication prescribed by the service. |
| <b>Risk Rating</b>      | Low                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Policy Standards</b> | Clinical Governance (Std 1)<br>Medication Safety (Std 4)                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Policy Sponsor</b>   | Director of Medical Services MHSDHS                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Policy Contact</b>   | Chief Pharmacist MHSDHS                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Version</b>          | 6.0                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Review Date</b>      | 18/03/2029                                                                                                                                                                                            |

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## 1. Aim

This policy outlines the criteria to be met for NMHS Mental Health Services (MHS) Community Mental Health patients to be granted approval for an exemption from payment for medication prescribed by the service.

## 2. Background

Health equity ensures sustainable and equitable health care is provided to the whole community where no one should be disadvantaged from attaining their full health potential. This policy is committed to advancing health equity by removing financial barriers that prevent individuals from accessing essential medications. This approach aligns with the principles outlined in the WA Health Sustainable Health Review (SHR) Final Report, which emphasises person-centred care, equity, and sustainability in the delivery of health services.

## 3. Risk

Failure to adhere to this policy puts patients at risk of being unable to access treatment. The organisation may be at risk with regard to financial management. There will be a risk that patients may become financially dependent on the service, inhibiting full recovery and discharge from the service.

Non-compliance with this policy will impact on the following risk categories:

|                                       |                                     |                                 |                                     |
|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Culture                               | <input type="checkbox"/>            | Organisational Development      | <input type="checkbox"/>            |
| Emergency Management                  | <input type="checkbox"/>            | Policy & Legislative Compliance | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Fiscal Responsibility                 | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | Quality of Patient Care         | <input type="checkbox"/>            |
| Governance & Accountability           | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> | Research & Innovation           | <input type="checkbox"/>            |
| Information Communications Technology | <input type="checkbox"/>            | Staff Safety & Wellness         | <input type="checkbox"/>            |
| Facility Management                   | <input type="checkbox"/>            | Workforce Planning              | <input type="checkbox"/>            |
| Medical Equipment                     | <input type="checkbox"/>            | Other                           | <input type="checkbox"/>            |

## 4. Principles

Patients of NMHS MHS Community will pay for prescription medication, with the exception of:

### 4.1 Category 1 Exemption: CTO

Where the patient is being treated under a CTO, the prescriber will provide a voucher indicating exemption from payment of a co-payment for all medication prescribed at the Community Mental Health Service.

The prescriber will indicate on the voucher that the patient is under a CTO Category 1 exemption, by selecting the appropriate category from the drop-down menu when creating the voucher in Best Practice® Prescribing Software, refer to [Appendix 2](#).

This will print Category 1 on the voucher under the tick box section indicating exemption from payment.

This will inform the NMHS MH Pharmacy Community Liaison team when processing claims/vouchers from community pharmacies what exemption category the patient is under for governance and compliance reporting.

For instructions on producing the voucher please see attached [Appendix 2](#) on how to write a NMHS voucher.

## 4.2 Category 2 Exemption: Weekly Clozapine Prescribing

Where a clozapine patient is prescribed a maximum of one week's supply of clozapine either for the first 18 weeks of therapy or for a re-titration caused by an interruption of therapy the patient will not be required to pay a co-payment for clozapine prescriptions.

**Note: This does not include other medication the patients may be prescribed by the community mental health clinic, and these will be required to be added to a separate voucher that indicates patient pays a co-payment.**

During the weekly prescribing period, the prescriber is able to provide a voucher indicating exemption from co-payment for clozapine prescriptions, by selecting the weekly clozapine Category 2 from the drop-down menu when creating the voucher in Best Practice® Prescribing Software, refer to [Appendix 2](#).

This will print Category 2 on the voucher under the tick box section indicating exemption from payment for the listed clozapine scripts.

This will inform the NMHS MH Pharmacy Community Liaison team when processing claims/vouchers from community pharmacies what exemption category the patient is under for governance and compliance reporting.

## 4.3 Category 3 Exemption: Hardship/Crisis

Where the prescriber believes that the patient is experiencing circumstances such that paying a co-payment for their medications is likely to lead to an inability to access prescribed treatment, the prescriber will apply to the local Service Managers for approval to grant exemption, using the [Patient Pharmacy Charges Exemption Form](#).

The prescriber must provide evidence that the patient suffers from a major mental illness that requires ongoing treatment by a multi-disciplinary community mental health service, plus at least one of the criteria stated outlined in Section 4.3.1. If approval is granted the prescriber may then provide an exemption for a maximum of 3 months.

When creating an exempt voucher during this period for medications the prescriber will indicate on the voucher that the patient is under a hardship/crisis Category 3 exemption, by selecting the appropriate category from the drop-down menu when creating the voucher in Best Practice® Prescribing Software.

This will print Category 3 on the voucher under the tick box section indicating exemption from payment. This will inform the NMHS MH Pharmacy Community Liaison team when processing claims/vouchers from community pharmacies what exemption category the patient is under for governance and compliance reporting.

Exemption must **not** be provided without prior approval of the local Service Manager. Approved exemption forms will be forwarded to the NMHS MH Pharmacy Community Liaison team for processing.

### 4.3.1 Criteria for Exemption

**Service Managers will not approve exemptions unless sufficient evidence is provided to establish that the patient meets the criteria below.**

The patient **MUST** suffer from a major mental illness that requires ongoing treatment by a multi-disciplinary community mental health service.

**Plus at least one of the following:**

- Patient suffering hardship (evidence of hardship must be presented by either the prescriber, case manager or social worker)
- Situational Crisis (social assessment and financial assessment is needed)
- Homeless or vulnerable (social assessment required)
- Not eligible for Medicare.

## 5. Review

The local Service Manager will review applications regularly. Approved applications will be sent to Pharmacy Community Liaison team (see [Appendix 1: Application for Exemption Flowchart](#)) for filing. If required, the local Service Manager will consult the local Head of Clinical Services if a clinical decision is required to make the final decision.

The local Service Manager will provide the reason why an application is not supported in a written response and return the application to the prescriber and Pharmacy Community Liaison team.

Exemption from payment for category 3 patients must be reviewed every 3 months. It is the prescriber's responsibility to ensure that approval is sought in a timely manner.

**Exemption may not be provided without prior approval. Prescriptions for patients must not exceed the time frame of the exemption.**

## 6. Maintaining List of Current Exemptions

The NMHS MHS Pharmacy Community Liaison team will be responsible for maintaining an up-to-date list of category 3 patients approved for exemption.

This list will be sent to all relevant NMHS MH Prescribers. This will allow for easy exemption checks and to remind the prescriber when exemption requires review and renewal.

The total number of exempt patients for all categories will be monitored from vouchers that are claimed by community pharmacies. These figures will be reported to mental health clinics on a monthly basis.

## 7. Monitoring and Evaluation

This policy will be audited by NMHS MH Pharmacy Services. Reports will be tabled at the Pharmaceutical Services Group meeting and provided to the local Head of Clinical Service and Service Managers on a monthly basis.

KPI's include:

- % of clinic patients granted exemption - Not more than 2%.
- Number of category 3 exempt vouchers provided without prior approval - 0

This policy will be evaluated as required to determine its currency, relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, and sustainability. At a minimum, it will be reviewed every 3 years using a risk management approach in accordance with the [NMHS Policy Governance Framework](#).

Refer to [NMHS Policy Document Glossary of Terms](#) for any other frequently used terms.

## 8. References

- [NSMHS Standard – Delivery of Care](#)
- [WA Health Fees and Charges Manual](#)

## 9. Resources

- [Sustainability Health Review – Final Report](#)
- [A snapshot of WA health system initiatives to improve health equity and access to care for people living in low socioeconomic conditions](#)
- [Patient Pharmacy Charges Exemption Application Form](#)

## 10. Document Control

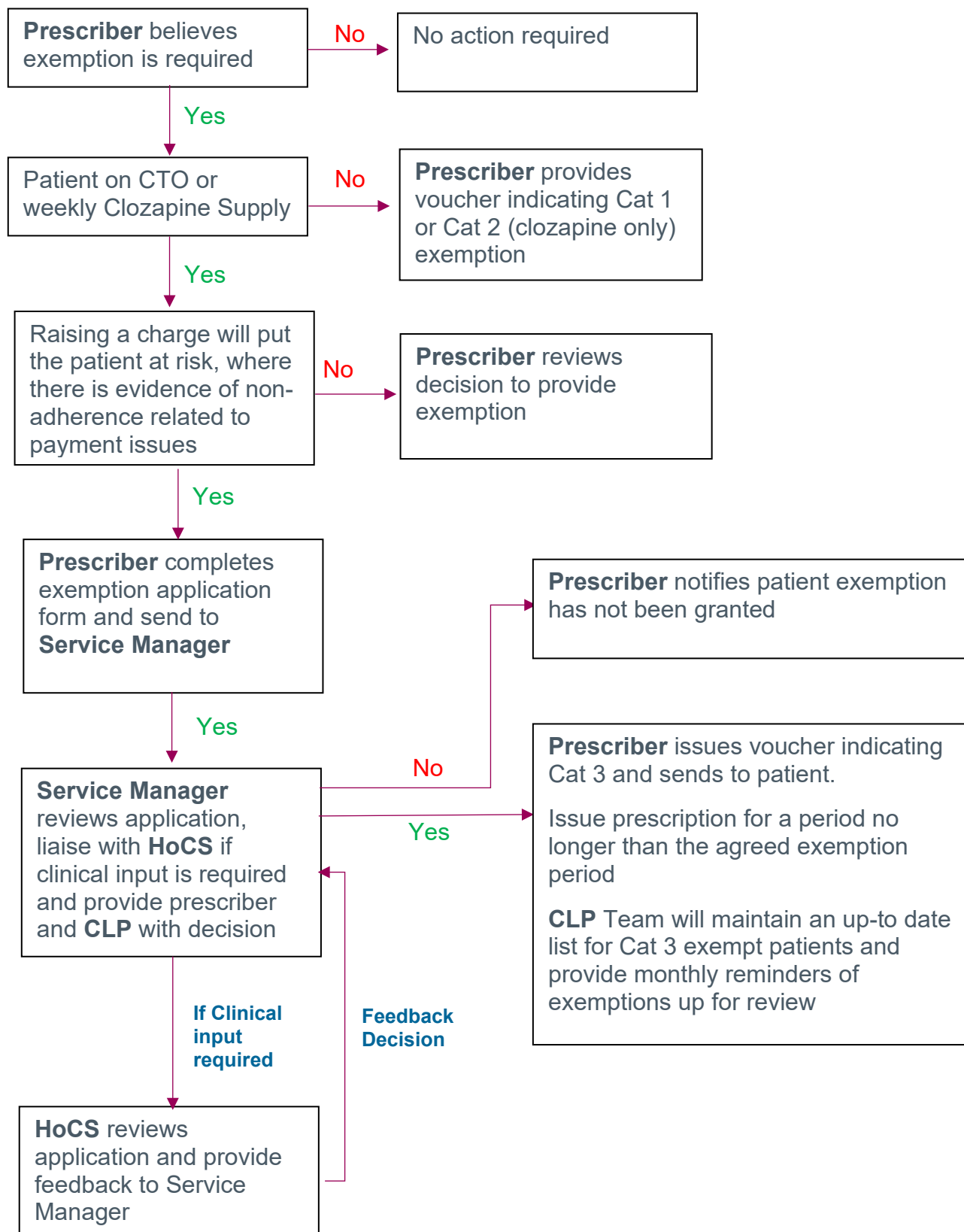
| AUTHORISATION: (For MH policies only – delete this box if not applicable) |                 |                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Committee Authorising Document                                            | Date Authorised | Minutes Ref. No.                        | Document Reference (e.g. MHEG Meeting Minutes)                                                                                                                                                                          |
| MHEG                                                                      | 24/10/2013      | 212/13                                  | MHEG Meeting Minutes                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| MHEG                                                                      | 16/03/2016      | 06/16                                   | MHEG Meeting Minutes                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| PSG                                                                       | 17/07/2017      |                                         | PSG Meeting Minutes                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| PSG                                                                       | 19/11/2017      | 09/3.2                                  | PSG Meeting Minutes                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| PSG                                                                       | 11/04/2019      | -                                       | PSG Meeting Minutes                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| MHEG                                                                      | 28/06/2019      | -                                       | Endorsed out of session via email                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Executive Director                                                        | 22/07/2019      | -                                       | Endorsed via submission form                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| PSG                                                                       | 28/5/2021       | -                                       | Endorsed out of session via email                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Document Version Control                                                  |                 |                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Date                                                                      | Version         | Author                                  | Notes                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| 14/06/2018                                                                | 4.1             | PSG Meeting                             | Inclusion of Weekly clozapine process and updating of flow chart to reflect this process.                                                                                                                               |
| 22/07/2019                                                                | 5.0             | Pharmacist, Graylands Hospital, NMHS MH | Scheduled Review: Updated template, uploaded hyperlinks and include NSQHS Standards V2.0. Removal of financial hardship/adding of exemption criteria and change of filing and maintenance of database to CI pharmacist. |
| 27/08/2020                                                                | 5.1             | Chief Pharmacist, NMHS MH               | Links updated                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 08/04/2021                                                                | 5.2             | PSG Meeting                             | Updating reporting of exemption type and voucher; new template                                                                                                                                                          |
| 08/2022                                                                   | 5.3             | Chief Pharmacist, NMHS MH               | Scheduled review, no content change, updated of template and hyperlinks                                                                                                                                                 |
| 18/03/2026                                                                | 6.0             | A/Chief Pharmacist, NMHS MH             | Scheduled review, new template, update on new background, new process for exemption approval.                                                                                                                           |

This document can be made available in alternative formats on request for a person with a disability.

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## Appendix 1: Application for Exemption Flowchart





## Appendix 2: Writing a NMHS MHS Voucher

When inside the patient's profile, select the Paper Icon. This will take you to the Letter Template screen

Mr Citizen Test

File Open Request Clinical Views Prescriptions PCEHR Help

Name: **Citizen Test** D.O.B.: 01/08/1951 Age: 69 yrs Sex: **Male** Family members: Mr Citizen Test [Jump] [Open]

Address: **NOT A REAL PATIENT no address NOT A REAL PATIENT** Phone: 90412301 Mobile: Work: [Finalise visit]

Medicare No.: Record No.: A9876543 Pension No.: Comment: **one week supply only at a time**

Occupation: Tobacco: **Ex smoker** Alcohol: Elite sports: Ethnicity:

Blood Group:

Allergies / Adverse Drug Reactions: **Reactions**

| Item       | Reaction    | Severity |
|------------|-------------|----------|
| Quetiapine | Pruritus    | Severe   |
| Olanzapine | Weight gain | Moderate |
| Olanzapine | apex        | Moderate |
| Olanzapine | Chest pain  | Mild     |

Actions/Reminders: **Preventive Health** **Actions** **Reminders**

| Type              | Due        | Reason                                                 |
|-------------------|------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Preventive health | 02/06/2021 | Vaccination against pneumococcus should be considered! |
| Preventive health | 02/06/2021 | A Dementia Risk Assessment should be considered!       |

Expand Collapse

Mr Citizen Test

Today's notes

Past visits

Current Rx

Past history

Immunisations

Investigation reports

Correspondence In

Correspondence Out

Past prescriptions

Observations

Family/Social history

Clinical images

Enhanced Primary Care

Add Edit Delete Print

Script date: 2/06/2021 [v] Tick the boxes of the items that you want to print. Items in red have been calculated to have been fully used.

| Drug name                                                   | Strength | Dose             | Quantity | Rpts. | Script type   | Long term | Last script | Approval No. | Subst. | Reg. 24 | First script | Reason for prescription | Comment |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|----------|------------------|----------|-------|---------------|-----------|-------------|--------------|--------|---------|--------------|-------------------------|---------|
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> Clozapine 50mg Tablet   | 50mg     | 1 in the evening | 56       | 0     | Section 100   | Yes       | 01/06/2021  |              | Yes    | No      | 10/05/2021   |                         |         |
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> Olanzapine 10mg Tablet  | 10mg     | 1 in the evening | 28       | 0     | PBS Authority | Yes       | / /         |              | Yes    | No      | 10/05/2021   | Sleep disorder          |         |
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> Quetiapine 25mg Tablet  | 25mg     | 1 in the evening | 120      | 5     | Non-PBS       | Yes       | 28/05/2021  |              | Yes    | No      | 10/05/2021   |                         |         |
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> Sertraline 100mg Tablet | 100mg    | 1 in the morning | 30       | 5     | PBS           | Yes       | 01/06/2021  |              | Yes    | No      | 10/05/2021   |                         |         |

Select the NMHS Voucher Template from your Template Favourites.

(If not loaded in favourites use the add button to find the NMHS Voucher)

If required follow the *How to add a template to favourites guide*

Best Practice Word Processor - Unlocked

File Edit View Insert Format Table Templates Utilities Help

Double click on an item in the list to insert it into the document.

General  
 Current user  
 Provider  
 Address  
 Other contact  
 Patient

Template favourites

Template name  
 Adult Referral Form WA Health  
 Amadeate EEP GP FU Template  
 Amadeate Eudoria Clozapine GP Letter  
 Amadeate Eudoria CTT GP Discharge template  
 Amadeate Eudoria CTT GP Discharge template  
 Amadeate Eudoria CTT GP FU Template  
 Amadeate Eudoria DST Discharge GP Template  
 Amadeate Eudoria DST GP Discharge Template  
 Amadeate Eudoria DST GP FU Template  
 Amadeate Eudoria Medical Certificate  
 Amadeate MH Patient Health Summary  
 Amadeate MHC Pharmacy Notification Form  
 CAHS Medication Letter  
 CAHS Parents Certificate  
 CLIN PHARM HITH VOUCHER 2021  
 CTG - Patient withdrawal consent  
 FCMH HTT VOUCHER 2021  
 FCMH VOUCHER 2021  
 FCMH VOUCHER 2021  
 FCMH VOUCHER 2021  
 FCMH VOUCHER 2021  
 Interim FCMH Voucher 2020  
 MHT Medical Report  
 New Voucher Template 2021 NMHS  
 NMHS HITH GP Contract Letter (Dentalup)  
 NMHS HITH GP Contract Letter (Dental)  
 NMHS LW template GP Letter  
 NMHS VOUCHER 2021  
 NMHS VOUCHER 2021  
 NMHS MH Clozapine Blood Count (Form 5)  
 NMHS MH Current RX and Past Prescriptions Letter  
 NMHS MH GP Letter Anx/Mood  
 NMHS MH GP Letter Clozapine  
 NMHS MH Letter Template  
 NMHS MH Medical Certificate  
 NMHS MH Medication Letter

Add Delete

Section1/1 Page1/1 Line1 Col0 100 % NMHS

Select the items to be added to the voucher and click insert

Insert current Rx

Tick the items to be inserted: ☐ No regular medications

| Drug                                                        | Dose             | Regular | Last script | Reason         |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|---------|-------------|----------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> Clozapine 50mg Tablet              | 1 In the evening | Yes     | //          |                |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Olanzapine 10mg Tablet             | 1 In the evening | Yes     | //          | Sleep disorder |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Quetiapine 25mg Tablet             | 1 In the evening | Yes     | 28/05/2021  |                |
| <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> Sertraline 100mg Tablet | 1 In the morning | Yes     | 31/05/2021  |                |

Select All Deselect All Insert Cancel

If the patient is not exempt from co-payments > select the 'Patient to pay a co-payment' > leave the exemption category as N/A. Next select DAA's required/ or NOT required. Then any interval in Dispensing/Supply if required.

New Voucher Template 2021 NMHS

Patient to pay co-payment? ☒

Patient NOT to pay co-payment? (Exemption Application Rq'd) ☐

Exemption Category CTO=1 Weekly CLZ=2 Hardship/Crisis =3 N/A

Dose administration aid? Dose administration aid NOT REQUIRED

Reduced intervals? Give THREE-FOUR DAYS of medication per supply (twice weekly)

DrName

Insert Cancel



If the patient is exempt from paying a co-payment, select Patient NOT to pay a co-payment. Then select the required category

CT0=1 Weekly Clozapine = 2 (only for clozapine scripts) Hardship/Crisis =3 (this exemption category required approval before providing a voucher). Then select the DAA's required or not and if any interval in

New Voucher Template 2021 NMHS

Patient to pay co-payment? ☐

Patient NOT to pay co-payment? (Exemption Application Rq'd\*) ☒

Exemption Category CT0=1 Weekly CLZ=2 Hardship/Crisis =3

Dose administration aid? ☐

Reduced intervals? ☐

DrName

3

Dose administration aid NOT REQUIRED  
Dose administration aid REQUIRED

Give THREE-FOUR DAYS of medication per supply (twice weekly)

Insert Cancel

This will indicate where applicable the type of exemption on the Voucher

 Government of Western Australia  
North Metropolitan Health Service  
Mental Health

**VOUCHER: AUTHORITY TO DIRECT PATIENT PHARMACY CHARGES TO A MENTAL HEALTH CLINIC**

To the Pharmacist: The Mental Health Clinic listed below will accept liability for this voucher if you have a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) agreement in place. Payment will be made according to the terms as set out in the MOU. This voucher is intended for medications addressing mental illness only.

☐ This patient will pay a co-payment for both PBS and non-PBS medication. This voucher will only cover the balance of charges for items not covered by the PBS including DAA and reduced interval charges if requested by the prescriber. Co-payment: \$6.60 Concession or Safety Net Concession, up to \$41.30 General (co-payments increase in line with the PBS), Safety Net Entitlement and CTG rules also apply for NON PBS medication where applicable

OR

☒ This patient should NOT be charged a co-payment for both PBS and non-PBS medication prescribed on 31/05/2021. This voucher covers all charges including DAA and reduced interval charges. Exemption Category: 3

|                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>PLEASE NOTE:</b> This is <b>NOT</b> a prescription.</p> <p>Drug strengths, directions for use and quantities on the attached prescriptions take precedence over those written on this form.</p> | <p><b>PATIENT DETAILS:</b>      A9876543</p> <p>Mr Citizen Test</p> <p>NOT A REAL PATIENT no address</p> <p>NOT A REAL PATIENT no address</p> <p>TEST 6666</p> |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

| DOCTOR TO COMPLETE THIS SECTION                                    | PHARMACY TO COMPLETE THIS SECTION |                   |                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-------------------|------------------|
| Medication/s to be subsidised<br>(directions for use NOT required) | Qty and repeats                   | Repeats remaining | Charge to clinic |
| Sertraline 100mg Tablet      1 In the morning                      |                                   |                   |                  |